TALK THREE

3 A Man of Sorrows, and Acquainted with Grief

"Surely he hath borne our griefs, and carried our sorrows: yet we did esteem him stricken, smitten of God, and afflicted."

ISAIAH 53:4

In the book of Acts, an Ethiopian official travels along the desert road from Jerusalem to Gaza, reading aloud from Isaiah in his chariot. He is the treasurer of Candace, queen of the Ethiopians, returning home after worshipping in Jerusalem. He has traveled a great distance to seek God, but he struggles to understand these words from Isaiah: "He was led as a sheep to the slaughter; and like a lamb dumb before his shearer, so opened he not his mouth."

The Spirit directs Philip, one of Jesus's followers, to the road. Philip hears the man reading and asks, "Understandest thou what thou readest?" The man answers, "How can I, except some man should guide me?"

He asks Philip, "Of whom speaketh the prophet this? of himself, or of some other man?" Acts says that Philip "began at the same scripture, and preached unto him Jesus." Philip explained that Isaiah's words pointed forward to Jesus and His suffering. Messiah and Christ mean "Anointed One." Suffering for us was part of what He was anointed to do. As we read Isaiah 53, we can keep the Ethiopian's question in mind: Who is Isaiah talking about?

Not everyone agrees that these words refer to Jesus. Many critics argue that early Christians looked at old scriptures and reinterpreted them to fit His life. Were the words written or changed after His life to line up? A discovery in 1947 helps answer that question. A shepherd found ancient scrolls in a cave near the Dead Sea, including a complete copy of Isaiah—all sixty-six chapters—copied more than a hundred years before Jesus was born. It

includes chapters 52 and 53. The words were there long before Christ's life. They were not written afterward to match it.

The passage the Ethiopian was studying begins at the end of chapter 52, with God saying, "Behold, my servant shall deal prudently, he shall be exalted and extolled, and be very high." Then we read that "his visage (or face) was so marred more than any man."

"Who hath believed our report?" Isaiah asks. People struggle to believe because the servant, who is Jesus, does not look like they want Him to. "He hath no form nor comeliness," they say, "and when we shall see him, there is no beauty that we should desire him. He is despised and rejected of men; a man of sorrows, and acquainted with grief: and we hid as it were our faces from him; he was despised, and we esteemed him not." To esteem someone is to value them. These people are admitting that they did not value Him. Instead, they saw Him and turned away.

Then they begin to understand what they had missed. "Surely he hath borne our griefs, and carried our sorrows: yet we did esteem him stricken, smitten of God, and afflicted." They had looked at His suffering and thought God was punishing Him. But Isaiah continues, "he was wounded for our transgressions, he was bruised for our iniquities: the chastisement of our peace was upon him; and with his stripes we are healed." The New International Version translates part of the verse this way: "the punishment that brought us peace was on him." Isaiah includes everyone here: "All we like sheep have gone astray; we have turned every one to his own way; and the Lord hath laid on him the iniquity of us all." They had thought He was suffering for something He had done. He was suffering for them.

Matthew connects this passage to Jesus's healings. One evening in Capernaum, Jesus healed the sick who were brought to Him. Matthew says this fulfilled Isaiah's words: "Himself took our infirmities, and bare our sicknesses." Jesus was carrying our grief before He was on the cross. He carried it in His early work as He touched and healed the sick.

Isaiah continues, "He was oppressed, and he was afflicted, yet he opened not his mouth: he is brought as a lamb to the slaughter, and as a sheep before her shearers is dumb, so he openeth not his mouth." Dumb here means

silent. This is the passage the Ethiopian was reading. When Jesus stood before Pilate, the governor, and was accused by the chief priests, Matthew says He "answered him to never a word," and Pilate marveled greatly.

Isaiah then says, "he was cut off out of the land of the living: for the transgression of my people was he stricken... he made his grave with the wicked, and with the rich in his death; because he had done no violence, neither was any deceit in his mouth... Yet it pleased the Lord to bruise him... when thou shalt make his soul an offering for sin, he shall see his seed... He shall see of the travail of his soul, and shall be satisfied: by his knowledge shall my righteous servant justify many; for he shall bear their iniquities." Travail means painful labor, a word also used for the pain of giving birth. After His suffering, the servant sees what His work has accomplished and is satisfied. Many are made righteous. The chapter ends by saying that "he was numbered with the transgressors; and he bare the sin of many, and made intercession for the transgressors."

Jesus said these words were about Him. On the night before His death, He told His disciples, "For I say unto you, that this that is written must yet be accomplished in me, And he was reckoned among the transgressors: for the things concerning me have an end." He quoted the last verse of Isaiah 53 and said it would be fulfilled in Him. The Ethiopian's question had been answered before he asked it.

The Book of Mormon prophets also taught that Isaiah was describing Christ. Abinadi, more than a century before Jesus was born, read this whole chapter to King Noah and his priests. A generation later, Alma taught the people of Gideon more about how the Savior's suffering would help us. He said the Son would go forth "suffering pains and afflictions and temptations of every kind." He would take on our infirmities "that his bowels may be filled with mercy, according to the flesh, that he may know according to the flesh how to succor his people according to their infirmities." Alma teaches that Jesus would know, through what He suffered in His own body, how to help us with our suffering. The Messiah was sent to bind up the brokenhearted, and the scriptures help us understand what that took.

The scriptures sometimes use the word suffer to mean allow, as when Jesus said, "Suffer the little children to come unto me." When we read about

Christ's sufferings, it is humbling to think that He allowed them. "He opened not his mouth," Isaiah said. I also think about the people who "esteemed him not." Do we look at people's suffering as their own fault? Would we recognize Jesus by His suffering?

Suffering alone does not make us holy. Christ was anointed to His suffering, and there are hard experiences that we have been called to as well. Allowing those experiences to change us means turning to God through them and learning to show more compassion to others who are hurting like we are. If we let Him teach us through what we face, we can become more like the Savior who is acquainted with our grief.

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The script ends here. The speaker's own testimony follows.